Portfolio Projects for BUSINESS COMMUNICATIONS

Project 1: Business Communications Overview



About the Presentations

- The presentations cover the objectives found in the opening of each chapter
- All chapter objectives are listed in the beginning of each presentation
- You may customize the presentations to fit your class needs
- Some figures from the chapters are included
  - A complete set of images from the book can be found on the Instructor Resources disc

Objectives

- Define business writing
- Identify reader action
- Develop clarity
- Identify formatting requirements
- Understand reader needs
- Use a positive tone
- Use writing tools in Word

Introduction

- In business, you write to accomplish goals in a timely manner
- Written documents should communicate a clear message that the reader can understand quickly and easily

Business Communication Essentials

- Activities in the business communication process:
  - Reader receives a document
    - In paper or electronic form
  - Reader reads the document
  - Reader understands the message
  - Message requires the reader to take action

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Business writing:
  - Communicates information a reader needs to take a specific action
  - Reader is central
- Identifying reader action:
  - Always keep in mind the action you want performed

Essentials (cont'd.)

Document	Expected Reader Action
Sales letter describing an exciting new tour of Antarctica	Purchase the tour
Letter requesting a recommendation	Provide you with a recommendation
Proposal to purchase a new computer system	Approve your proposal
Letter offering a job to an applicant	Accept the job
E-mail asking to attend a meeting	Attend the meeting

Figure 1-1 Sample reader actions

Essentials (cont'd.)

VERSION 1 – Expected Action Unclear

As a student in your business communication course a few years ago, I learned a great deal about how to communicate effectively with my reader. Since taking your course, I have worked for two companies. Both jobs have really helped me improve my communication skills. Now I need a new challenge and so I'm applying for a new job as a marketing assistant with Preston Consultants in Seattle. I just know that my qualifications are perfectly suited for this new job and, even better, the job is close to my home and provides great benefits. I hope you'll let me know if you're able to help me. Thank you!

VERSION 2 – Expected Action Clarified

I was a student in your business communication course two years ago. At the end of the course, you very kindly gave me permission to use your name as a reference to help me with my job search efforts. You also said that you would write a letter of recommendation.

I have applied for a position as a marketing assistant with Preston Consultants in Seattle. Janet Cox, the personnel director, has asked me for a reference from one of my college instructors. Could you send a letter of recommendation to Sally Lee at 208 Bayview Drive, Seattle, WA, 98241?

Please call me at 206-555-2233 if you would like to discuss my request or require further information. I appreciate your help in this matter.

Figure 1-2 Vague and action-oriented messages

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Version 1:
  - Does not provide enough information
  - Reader will probably reply for more information or ignore the message
- Version 2:
  - Tells exactly what to do and how to do it
  - Clear request with specific details

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Techniques to develop clarity:
  - Select precise words

Vague Sentence	Problems and Comments	Precise Meaning
Your order will be filled soon.	What order? When will it be filled?	Your order for 300 electric cars will be filled by May 3.
The report is full of errors.	What report? What errors?	The *Water Sources on Bowen Island* report contains several grammatical errors and incorrectly states that all residents receive water from wells.
We are meeting later today.	Who is meeting? When? Why?	The Sales Department will meet at 4 p.m. today (June 3) to analyze the 2011 sales figures.

Figure 1-3 Rewriting vague sentences

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Techniques to develop clarity (cont'd.):
  - Use active voice
  - Active voice sentence:
    - Noun performing the action comes before the verb and is the subject
    - Example: The shipping clerk purchased the packing materials.

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Techniques to develop clarity (cont'd.):
  - Passive voice sentence:
    - Noun performing the action follows the verb and is the direct object
    - Example: The packing materials were purchased by the shipping clerk.

Essentials (cont'd.)

Passive Voice	Active Voice
The sales representatives were questioned by the marketing director.	The marketing director questioned the sales representatives.
The rent was raised.	The landlord raised the rent. *Note:* In this passive sentence, no noun performs the action (raised). To put the sentence into the active voice, you must supply a subject, such as *The landlord*, in this example.
The store was overwhelmed with hundreds of customers rushing in to buy the latest bestseller.	Hundreds of customers rushed into the store to purchase the latest bestseller.
The refund check for $400 was issued by Acacia Financing.	Acacia Financing company issued a refund check for $400.

Figure 1-4 Passive vs. active voice

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Techniques to develop clarity (cont'd.):
  - Use everyday vocabulary
  - Instead of using old-fashioned stock phrases that contribute little, find phrases such as:
    - Thank you for contacting me regarding…

Wordy Stock Phrase	Conversational Alternative
In the event that	If
Due to the fact that	Because
Please do not hesitate to call me.	Please call me.
I'd like to take this opportunity to thank you.	Thank you.
I'd be more than happy to accede to your request.	I am happy to assist you. (How can you be more than happy?)
It has come to my attention	No alternative; omit use of this phrase

Figure 1-5 Common stock phrases

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Techniques to develop clarity (cont'd.):
  - Eliminate wordiness

Wordy Sentence	Reader Response	Straight to the Point
Your application, which we received with pleasure last week, will be reviewed by us at a later date yet to be decided.	*Just tell me when you will review my application.*	We will review your application by July 30.
I wish to take this opportunity to extend my thanks to you for the work that you did to help me on the account we worked on from the Carter company.	*I'm in danger of falling asleep before I get to the end of this sentence.*	Thank you for helping me with the Carter account.
The meeting that will be held on May 3 will need to address a variety of issues that are all in some way related to our participation in the upcoming sales conference.	*What are we meeting about?*	On May 3, we will meet to discuss our participation in the June sales conference.

Figure 1-6 Eliminating wordy sentences

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Identify formatting requirements:
  - Effectively formatted documents are clear and easy to understand
  - Reader can see at a glance the purpose and main points

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Identify formatting requirements (cont'd.):
  - Adapt document layout
    - Layout is the positioning of the text on the page

Essentials (cont'd.)

Version 1: Poor Layout

Thank you for your order to ship 300 ceramic garden pots from Toronto to Paris. Your shipment will leave our warehouse on May 1.
Here is the information related to your shipment:
Items: 300 ceramic garden pots
Packing methodFoam chips/foam-lined crates
Receiving distributor (Paris): Marie Fontaine at France Air
100 rue de Charenton 75011 Paris
Packing cost: $1200
Shipping cost: $800
The total cost of your order is $2000 plus 7% tax for a total of $2140. Our invoice, which includes package tracking information, is attached. If I can be of further assistance, please call me at (416) 555-1299. Thank you again for placing your order with Go Green Packing.

Version 2: Professional Layout

Thank you for your order to ship 300 ceramic garden pots from Toronto to Paris. Your shipment will leave our warehouse on May 1.

Here is the information related to your shipment:

Items:	300 ceramic garden pots
Packing method	Foam chips/foam-lined crates
Receiving distributor (Paris):	Marie Fontaine at France Air
	100 rue de Charenton 75011 Paris
Packing cost:	$1200
Shipping cost:	$800
Subtotal	$2000
Tax	$140
Total	$2140

Our invoice, which includes package tracking information, is attached. If I can be of further assistance, please call me at (416) 555-1299. Thank you again for placing your order with Go Green Packing.

Figure 1-7 Layout comparison

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Identify formatting requirements (cont'd.):
  - Version 1:
    - Cramped
    - Inconsistent spacing
  - Version 2:
    - More white space around the text
    - Positioning makes information stand out
    - List (bullet) format is also effective

Essentials (cont'd.)

Sentence Version

The reader needs to mentally separate out the items and may miss something.

I will be pleased to process your order as soon as we receive a sample vase, the packing option you require (foam chips or bubble wrap), the distributor's contact information, and customs forms.

List Version

The reader can check off each item to be sure nothing is missed.

I will be pleased to process your order as soon as we receive the following items:

- Sample vase
- Packing option required (foam chips or bubble wrap)
- Distributor's contact information
- Customs forms

Figure 1-8 Comparison of information presented in a sentence and in a list

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Identify formatting requirements (cont'd.):
  - Appearance and layout can be perfect yet still fail to communicate
  - Organize content to promote understanding

Essentials (cont'd.)

Version 1: Plain Text

The Marketing Department at Go Green Packing has developed three kinds of printed materials to advertise our new shipping options: brochures, bookmarks, and posters. Each type of printed material includes descriptions and pricing options for the packing options. We suggest you send the brochure to customers on your mailing list and include the bookmark with every purchase of packing materials. You can send the poster to post offices, company mailrooms, and retail warehouses in your target area.

Version 2: Content Organized with Headings

New Marketing Materials

The Marketing Department at Go Green Packing has developed three kinds of marketing materials to advertise our new shipping options. Each type of printed material includes descriptions and pricing options for the packing options. Please distribute these materials as follows:

Brochures

Send to all customers on your mailing list.

Bookmarks

Include a bookmark with every purchase of packing materials.

Posters

Send to post offices, company mail rooms, and retail warehouses in your target area.

Figure 1-9 Comparison of plain text content and organized content

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Identify formatting requirements (cont'd.):
  - Techniques to organize content
    - Headings and subheadings
    - Lists
    - Tables

Essentials (cont'd.)

Version 1: Content presented in a paragraph

The reader needs to study the paragraph closely to determine when to perform each action.

Arrive at 7:15 a.m. and open the premises. The alarm needs to be disarmed. Prepare the coffee. At 7:30 a.m. ensure that the doors to the public are unlocked. Greet customers and direct them to the appropriate department. Take a 15-minute break at 10:30 and 2:30. Take lunch at noon for 30 minutes. No customers should be admitted after 4:30 p.m. At 4:45 p.m., contact the janitorial staff and provide directions regarding specific areas to clean. At 5:00 p.m., the premises need to be locked and the alarm needs to be set before you leave the premises.

Version 2: Content presented in table form

The reader can see at a glance exactly what to do throughout the day.

Daily Schedule

Time	Activity
7:15	Open the premises and disarm the alarm
7:20	Prepare coffee
7:30	Unlock the doors to admit customers
7:30 to 4:30	Greet customers and direct them to the appropriate department
10:30 to 10:45	Morning break
Noon to 12:30	Lunch
2:30 to 2:45	Afternoon break
4:30	Close the doors to customers
4:45	Advise the janitorial staff about specific areas to clean
5:00	Lock the premises and set the alarm

Figure 1-10 Organizing content in a table form

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Understanding reader needs:
  - A business document may be formatted clearly and still not communicate effectively
  - Identify reader needs
    - Reader must understand and then be able to act accordingly
    - Use 5W technique: Who, What, Where, When, Why, and How

Essentials (cont'd.)

Question Word	Sample Question	Sample Answers
Who	Whom should we hire?	Specify the person's name and qualifications if you have someone specific in mind. Suggest a method for recruiting if you need to hire someone. For example, suggest advertising in the local paper or contacting an employment agency.
What	What duties would the new assistant perform?	Refer to a job description supplied by the Human Resources Department, if available, to identify the duties required and then list them in the memo. Use a bulleted list to present the duties in an easy-to-read format.
Where	Where would the new assistant work? For example, is a new workstation or computer needed?	Identify an area in the office that would be suitable for a new workstation. The supervisor will also want to know if new equipment and office furniture are required. If so, identify the costs involved.
When	When should we hire the assistant?	Specify when the new assistant should start, as well as a possible work schedule. Will the assistant work part-time? Full-time?
Why	Why should we hire an assistant?	Provide a rationale for hiring the assistant. How can the assistant help the business? The supervisor will want to know if spending money on a new assistant will contribute to making the office more productive and, most importantly, more profitable.
How	How much should we pay the assistant?	Research the pay scale for assistants in similar positions and then provide the supervisor with a range.

Figure 1-11 Sample questions and answers to identify reader needs

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Understanding reader needs (cont'd.):
  - Use reader-centered vocabulary
    - Focus on the reader, not on the writer

Essentials (cont'd.)

Version 1: Writer-centered message

We note with pleasure that our Web site was visited and a request for a copy of our Spring 2011 catalog was made. We are pleased to enclose our catalog along with a free sample of our new Premium Best Bubble Wrap.

Our online questionnaire was completed which resulted in a request for our shipping products. Pages 3 to 12 in the catalog provide a full list of our shipping products. We've also included in our catalog our reference guide to all the packing supplies for retail operations that we carry.

Again, we thank you for requesting one of our Go Green Packing 2011 catalogs. Please call us at (206) 555-1299 or e-mail us at orders@gogreenpacking.com to place an order. Remember that our new secure online ordering system can also be used to order our products directly from our Web site at www.gogreenpackingcorp.com.

Version 2: Reader-centered message

Thank you for visiting the Go Green Packing Web site and requesting a copy of the Spring 2011 catalog. Enclosed are a catalog and a free sample of Premium Best Bubble Wrap. You can use Premium Best to protect delicate objects such as china and glassware.

When you completed the online questionnaire, you mentioned your interest in shipping products. You will find a full list of these products on pages 3 to 12 in the catalog, as well as a reference guide at the back of the catalog that lists all packing supplies for retail operations.

Again, thank you for requesting a Go Green Packing 2011 catalog. If you would like to place an order or if you have further questions, please call me at (206) 555-1299 or e-mail me at orders@gogreenpacking.com. You can also log on to www.gogreenpackingcorp.com and place your order.

Figure 1-13 Writer-centered and reader-centered vocabulary

Essentials (cont'd.)

- Understanding reader needs (cont'd.):
  - Use a positive tone

Negative Version	Positive Version	Comments
This report contains too many errors to submit to the Board as written.	Please correct punctuation and grammar in the report on Relocation Options before submitting it to the Board.	Tell the reader what actions can be taken to correct the problem rather than focusing only on the problem.
Your application for the position of marketing manager has been rejected.	The successful candidate had over 15 years of experience in a similar position.	Saying *no* in a way that retains the reader's goodwill requires some finesse—and a specific structure, which you will study in more detail in a later project.
We are sorry to hear of the problem you've had with our product.	Thank you for letting us know about the loose bolts on the chair you purchased from us on July 3. We will certainly exchange the chair for a new one.	The customer never has a problem! Acknowledge the reader and the specific situation, and then provide assistance.
There is nothing to be done about the team's total lack of ideas.	The team needs to work together to develop new ideas. I suggest we ask a facilitator to help us get back on track.	Find a positive action.

Figure 1-14 Using a positive tone

Essentials (cont'd.)

Thank you for requesting packing services from Go Green Packing. I understand that your company manufactures glass vases and that you need to know the cost of packing 3000 vases for shipment to Asia.

I will be pleased to send you a cost estimate as soon as we receive the following items:

- Sample vase
- Packing option (foam chips or bubble wrap)
- Distributor's contact information
- Customs forms

Please send us the above information by June 30 so that I can provide a cost estimate for your order. If you have any questions or require further assistance, please call me at (206) 555-1299. Thank you for your interest in Go Green Packing. I look forward to hearing from you.

Figure 1-15 Example of a positively-worded message

Technology Skills
Using Writing Tools in Word

- Microsoft Word includes a variety of tools to help you write clearly and effectively
  - Thesaurus
    - Helps you find synonyms and antonyms that clarify your meaning
  - Spelling and Grammar feature
    - Checks for errors
    - Finds passive voice sentences

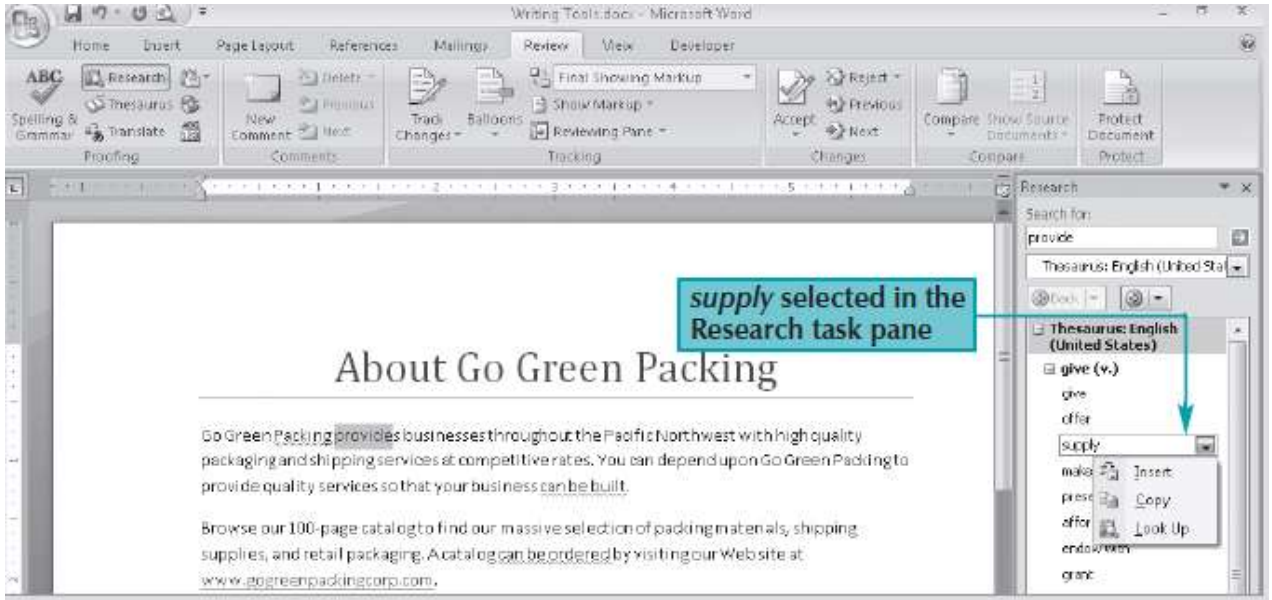
Writing Tools in Word (cont'd.)

To use the Thesaurus feature:

1. Open the file **Tech_01.docx** located in the Project.01 folder included with your Data Files and then, to avoid altering the original file, save the document as **Writing Tools** in the same folder.
2. Read the description of Go Green Packing. As you can see, the word *provide* appears three times (once as *provides*), and other adjectives such as *massive* and *brilliant* do not sound quite right for a business document.
3. Press [**Ctrl**]+[**F**] to open the Find and Replace dialog box, type **provide**, click the **Find Next** button, and then click the **Cancel** button to close the Find and Replace dialog box. The word *provides* is not very precise and is certainly overused in this document.
4. Click the **Review** tab, and then click the **Thesaurus** button in the Proofing group. The Research task pane opens showing a list of synonyms for *provide*.
5. Click **supply** in the list of synonyms. Another list of synonyms for *supply* appears. After studying the list, you decide you prefer *supply*.
6. Click the **Back** button near the top of the Research task pane, move the mouse pointer over **supply**, then click the **list arrow** that appears, as shown in Figure 1-16.

Figure 1-16 Using the Thesaurus

Writing Tools in Word (cont'd.)



7. Click **Insert**, and then change **supply** to **supplies**.
8. Select **provide** in the last line of paragraph 1, click the right mouse button, point to **Synonyms**, and then click **offer**.
9. Use the Thesaurus to replace **massive** and **brilliant** with the synonyms **huge** and **expert**, or similar words. Note that you can click several synonyms to see additional synonyms for the word you clicked until you find one that best reflects your meaning.
10. Click the **Close** button to close the Research task pane.

Figure 1-16 Using the Thesaurus (cont'd.)

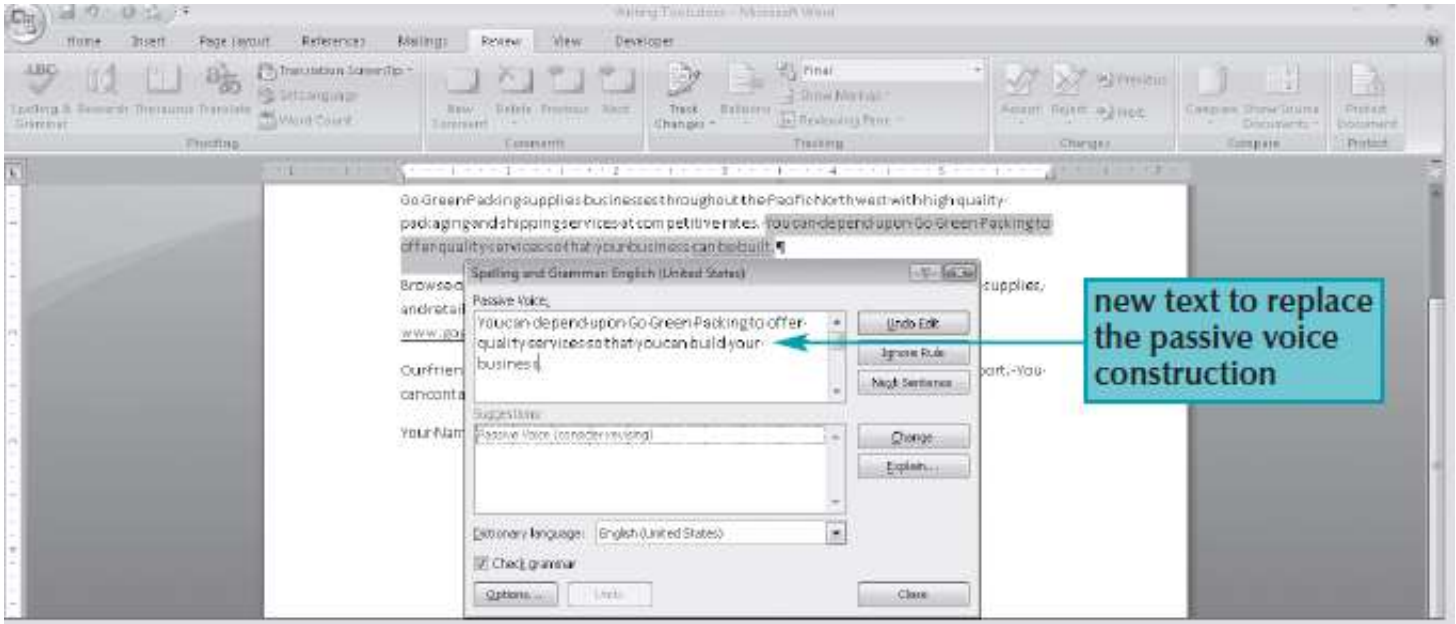
Writing Tools in Word (cont'd.)

To find passive voice sentences:

1. Click the **Office** button, click **Word Options**, and then click **Proofing**.
2. Click the **Mark grammar errors as you type** check box (the Check grammar with spelling check box will also be selected) if it is not already selected, click the **Writing Style** list arrow, click **Grammar & Style**, click the **Settings** button, scroll down and be sure the **Passive Sentences** check box in the Style area is checked, click **OK**, click **Recheck Document**, click **Yes**, and then click **OK**.
3. Click the **Spelling & Grammar** button in the Proofing group, and then, if the sentence with *Pacific time* is highlighted, click **Ignore Once**. The Grammar check thinks *time* is a capitalization error; however, it is correct as lowercase, so you ignore the error.
4. Click **Ignore Once** to skip Your Name, and then, if *Packing* in the first sentence is highlighted, click **Ignore Once**. The Grammar check thinks *Packing* is a capitalization error; however, since it is part of the company name, you ignore the error. The construction *can be built* is highlighted because it is in the passive voice.
5. Click **Explain**, read the description of the passive voice, then close the Word Help dialog box.
6. Select the text **your business can be built** in the Spelling and Grammar dialog box, and then type **you can build your business** as shown in Figure 1-17.

Figure 1-17 Correcting a passive voice sentence

Writing Tools in Word (cont'd.)



7. Click **Change**, note that the passive construction **can be ordered** is highlighted, select **A catalog can be ordered** in the Spelling and Grammar dialog box, type **You can order a catalog**, click **Change**, and then click **OK**.
8. Type your name where indicated, save the document, print a copy, and then close the document.

Figure 1-17 Correcting a passive voice sentence (cont'd.)